

MOUNTING CRISIS BJP workers burn an effigy of Punjab cabinet minister Laljit Bhullar in Patiala, Mar. 23



PUNJAB

SUICIDE, VIDEO AND GRAINS OF TRUTH?

Pushed to the wall, an official ends his life and puts out a video listing the cause. It's bad news for the AAP regime

of danger. As the air heated up, Mann ordered the minister to put in his papers so as not to impede an impartial probe. On March 23, following raising of the issue in Parliament by Amritsar MP G.S. Aujla, all seven Congress MPs from Punjab, along with Akali Dal's Harsimrat Badal, wrote to union Home Minister Amit Shah seeking a CBI inquiry. The same day, Bhullar was arrested.

Randhawa's video, read along with the FIR filed by his widow, paints a picture not very congruent with AAP's ethics-first image. Bhullar was allegedly coercing Randhawa to allot a warehouse tender to his father, threatening dire consequences if he did not comply.

Takeaways

- **Gagandeep Randhawa, a Punjab Warehousing official, ends his life in desperation**
- **Suicide video blames jails minister Laljit Bhullar. FIR alleges coercion for a favour**
- **AAP faces political storm a year before assembly poll**
- **Congress and Akali Dal write to union Home Minister Amit Shah seeking a CBI inquiry. Bhullar is arrested**

When Randhawa instead issued a tender as per rules, Bhullar allegedly scaled up the pressure—the FIR says Randhawa was threatened at gunpoint at the minister's residence on March 13 to retract the tender or be forced to sign off on a 'confession' that he had made a wrongful allotment for a bribe. On March 21 night, the official consumed pesticide.

Randhawa's position placed him at a nodal point in Amritsar's procurement and storage operations—with additional charge of Tarn Taran district. It was his job to oversee warehousing facilities, including those connected with the Food Corporation of India. Vendor selection was the key part here.

Randhawa is said to have written to his seniors, flagging threats and coercion, to no avail. Even after the suicide, the government initially responded administratively, marking an inquiry to chief secretary K.A.P. Sinha. Only after Randhawa's video surfaced, and his family named Bhullar, did it bend to the political firestorm that ensued.

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"This is not an isolated incident," said Leader of Opposition Partap Singh Bajwa, of the Congress. "It reflects the environment in which officers are being forced to function." Akali Dal leader Bikram Singh Majithia, who aborted a party rally in Dera Baba Nanak to reach the family of the deceased, said, "If an officer is being pushed to this extent, it raises serious questions about how decisions are being influenced." The FIR was only registered subsequently—timing that has since come under attack. "That sequence itself needs to be examined," said state BJP chief Sunil Jakhar. Mann says no one will be spared, and due process was followed scrupulously.

AAP had come to power on a governance plank that emphasised clean processes. Critics allege it did not stay immune to the old patterns, where contracts and clearances brought political interests into play. After this episode, staving off allegations will likely take more than high rhetoric. ■